

SILENT PRESENCE An AI generated picture of a drone over Srinagar

CHALLENGES

- Need for more local investment in defence-drone startups
- Government incentives linked to design and product performance needed
- Promotion of faster adoption of technology breakthroughs

AI generated image by HARDIK CHHABRA

THE CHANGE-MAKERS

GENERAL ATOMICS

Dr Vivek Lall, the chief executive of the company, played a key role during the India–US talks in the deal to procure MQ–9B drones

iDEAFORGE

The Mumbai-based UAV firm has emerged as a reliable source of drones for the Indian military. Over 200 SWITCH drones made by the company are used for surveillance along the LAC

PARAS DEFENCE AND SPACE TECHNOLOGIES

With a focus on modern warfare, the Mumbai company, headed by CEO Pankaj Akula, has introduced its Archer–B8 UCAV attack drone. Archer–B8 has been fully designed and developed indigenously



"Drones give the strategic advantage of enhanced situational awareness to soldiers. The time has come when the soldier can enter a battlefield without an assault rifle but not without a drone"

–PANKAJ AKULA, *CEO, Paras Defence Space Technologies*

the Indian military's response to the Chinese combat drone, the Wing Loong II, which is being acquired by Pakistan.

SkyGuardian and SeaGuardian drones can cover all air bases and military installations in Pakistan while flying along the LoC and can provide real-time information on Chinese military assets while deployed over the LAC—a true game changer. However, with the long-drawn acquisition process still in its early stages, it will take years before the MQ-9Bs arrive. For surveillance, the Indian military also uses the indigenous SWITCH drones, as well as the Israeli-made Heron and Searcher drones. The air force also has in its arsenal Israeli-origin Harop 'Kamikaze' attack drones.

WHAT INDIA NEEDS TO MASTER

Indian Unmanned Aerial Vehicle (UAV) firms must develop hi-tech capabilities to develop drones that can match top US, Israeli and Chinese UAVs. The Indian drone ecosystem must widen further in sophistication to reduce its dependence on imports. It will help the country save money on these highly expensive platforms. ■